

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
1/7/2026

The meeting was called to order by coordinator Sally Garratt at 6:40pm. There were seven people present. The minutes of the December meeting were approved as presented.

The proposed Equine Economic Impact Survey was discussed. Leslie stated that the committee is gathering names of horse people on Whidbey to create a contact list for the survey. Bruce will update the member list for the Whidbey Island Trail Riders whose names will be included on that list. The format of the survey was discussed and how to count the information was also considered...i.e. count expenditures or receipts? Also we should consider other aspects of horse ownership such as tax advantages for pasture land, open spaces and other expenses/receipts related to keeping equines. The committee emphasized the importance of maintaining the credibility of the survey. The Committee has established a deadline of April 15th for the roll out of the survey. They will also talk with Betsy about a communications plan.

No one was present to discuss the Horse Directory so that was tabled until the next meeting. We will include Thora on all communications (her email address was obtained) to better understand what needs to be done about the Directory.

Bell's Farm has reportedly been taken off the market and no information was presented regarding the status of the Farm other than that there is ongoing litigation between the current owners and the Land Trust.

A new project was discussed regarding an island-wide emergency plan for large animals. We will try to coordinate with the groups now planning for contingencies during a major disaster for humans to include plans for large animals. Peggy will check with the South Whidbey group and Barb will work on this project when she returns from Mexico. We will try to attend the training now scheduled for February.

We discussed having another island/wide social event for all horse owners, riders and equine-interested people. We will include this topic for next months meeting.

The meeting was adjourned at 7:45pm. The next meeting will be held at 6:30pm on February 4, 2026 at the Race Road Fire Station.